

CLASS 10 CBSE ENGLISH - FIRST FLIGHT

Chapter 3 & Poems: Two Stories About Flying • How to Tell Wild Animals • The Ball Poem

Coverage: NCERT exercise solutions, paragraph/stanza explanations, themes, character sketches, poetic devices, important quotations, word meanings, extract-based practice, short/long answers, value-based questions and CBSE-oriented questions. Answers are written in simple, exam-ready English.

PART I - TWO STORIES ABOUT FLYING

I. His First Flight - Liam O'Flaherty

A. Oral Comprehension Check - His First Flight

1. Why was the young seagull afraid to fly?

Answer: The young seagull was afraid because he thought his wings would not support him. He had watched his brothers and sister fly, but he lacked the confidence to make the first attempt. His fear prevented him from discovering his own ability.

2. What did the parents do to encourage him to fly?

Answer: His parents tried different ways to make him fly. They scolded and threatened him, then flew around him and called him. Finally, his mother came close with a piece of fish but stopped just beyond his reach. Hunger forced him to dive towards the food, and he discovered that he could fly.

3. What was the first food the young seagull ate?

Answer: He ate the fish that his mother had brought. The desire for food finally overcame his fear and made him take the first flight.

4. How did the family celebrate his first flight?

Answer: His parents flew around him, making loud noises and encouraging him. His brother and sister also flew around him. The family's joyful response showed that they were proud of him and that he had successfully overcome his fear.

B. Thinking About the Text - His First Flight

1. Describe the young seagull's feelings before and after his first flight.

Answer: Before flying, the seagull was frightened, hesitant and lacking confidence. He believed that he would fall if he tried. After jumping towards the fish, he realised that his wings could support him. His fear disappeared and was replaced by excitement, confidence and joy.

2. What is the message of the story?

Answer: The story teaches that fear often prevents us from recognising our abilities. Confidence may come only when we take the first step. With encouragement and necessity, we can overcome hesitation and discover that we are capable of much more than we imagine.

3. Why did the young seagull finally make the attempt to fly?

Answer: He was extremely hungry. His mother brought a piece of fish and held it just out of his reach. His hunger became stronger than his fear, so he jumped towards the food. During the jump, he discovered that he could fly.

4. Do you think the parents were right in forcing the young seagull to fly?

Answer: Their method was strict, but it helped the young seagull overcome a fear that he could not overcome on his own. They understood that he had to experience flying for himself. Their final encouragement and the food helped him take the necessary first step.

C. Character Sketch - Young Seagull

Young Seagull: Initially timid, fearful and unsure of himself; however, he is also capable of learning. His hunger and his mother's strategy force him to act. Once he discovers that he can fly, he becomes confident and joyful. He represents people who possess ability but hesitate because of fear.

II. The Black Aeroplane - Frederick Forsyth

D. Oral Comprehension Check - The Black Aeroplane

1. Why was the pilot flying into the storm?

Answer: The pilot wanted to reach home quickly. Although he saw huge dark clouds ahead, he decided to continue rather than turn back. This decision placed him in danger.

2. What problems did the pilot face inside the storm?

Answer: The storm caused violent movement and darkness. His compass stopped working, his radio stopped functioning and he could not see the ground. His fuel was also running low, making the situation increasingly dangerous.

3. Who helped the pilot when he was lost?

Answer: A mysterious pilot in a black aeroplane appeared and signalled him to follow. The narrator followed the aircraft and was guided safely out of the storm.

4. Why was the narrator surprised after landing?

Answer: The narrator discovered that the control-room woman said there had been no other aircraft in the sky. She also said that the narrator had no way of knowing where he was because there was only one aircraft reported on the radar. This made the identity of the mysterious pilot puzzling.

E. Thinking About the Text - The Black Aeroplane

1. What do you think the black aeroplane was?

Answer: The story deliberately leaves this question mysterious. It may be interpreted as a supernatural or unexplained phenomenon, or as a mysterious helper whose identity is never revealed. The author does not provide a definite explanation.

2. What did the narrator do when he saw the black aeroplane?

Answer: He tried to contact the pilot by radio, but there was no response. He then followed the aircraft because he was lost and had very little fuel. The black aeroplane led him out of the storm.

3. Why did the narrator not contact Paris Control before entering the storm?

Answer: He had already decided to take the risk of flying through the storm and was focused on reaching home. Once inside the storm, his radio stopped working, making communication impossible.

4. Why is the story called 'The Black Aeroplane'?

Answer: The black aeroplane is the central mystery of the story. It appears unexpectedly, guides the narrator to safety and then seems to disappear without any trace. The title therefore draws attention to the mysterious aircraft and the unanswered question surrounding it.

F. Additional Theoretical Questions - Two Stories About Flying

1. What common idea connects 'His First Flight' and 'The Black Aeroplane'?

Answer: Both stories involve flying and danger, but they explore different experiences. The first is about overcoming fear and gaining confidence; the second is about mystery, uncertainty and unexpected help.

2. How does the mother seagull help her son overcome fear?

Answer: She uses the seagull's hunger as motivation. By bringing food and keeping it just beyond his reach, she makes him jump. Once he is airborne, he realises that he can fly.

3. What does the young seagull's first flight symbolise?

Answer: It symbolises overcoming fear, gaining independence and discovering one's abilities through experience.

4. Why is the ending of 'The Black Aeroplane' mysterious?

Answer: The narrator reaches safety with the help of an apparently unknown pilot, but the control-room officer says that no other plane was visible or reported. The story gives no final explanation, leaving the

reader to interpret the event.

5. Compare the role of fear in the two stories.

Answer: Fear is central in 'His First Flight' because the young seagull must overcome it. In 'The Black Aeroplane', fear arises from being trapped in a storm with failing instruments and little fuel. One story resolves fear through self-discovery; the other ends with mystery.

G. Important Words & Meanings - Stories About Flying

Word	Meaning
Plunge	To fall or dive suddenly and steeply.
Herring	A type of fish used as food.
Mackerel	A sea fish.
Seagull	A seabird commonly found near seas and coasts.
Lurking	Remaining hidden while waiting for something.
Terror	Extreme fear.
Storm	A violent disturbance of weather.
Compass	An instrument used for finding direction.
Radar	A system used to detect and locate objects, including aircraft.
Mystery	Something unexplained or difficult to understand.

PART II - HOW TO TELL WILD ANIMALS

Carolyn Wells

A. Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1 - Asian Lion

Answer: The poet humorously says that if a large wild animal approaches while travelling in Asia and the animal roars loudly, it may be an Asian lion. The exaggerated situation creates humour while presenting the danger playfully.

Stanza 2 - Bengal Tiger

Answer: The poet describes a Bengal tiger as a large yellow animal with black stripes. If it leaps at a person and kills them, the victim can identify it as a Bengal tiger. The comic exaggeration makes the description memorable.

Stanza 3 - Leopard

Answer: A leopard is described through its behaviour. If a spotted animal keeps leaping upon a person repeatedly, it is a leopard. The poet uses repetition and exaggeration for comic effect.

Stanza 4 - Bear

Answer: The poet says that if a large animal hugs a person very tightly, it may be a bear. The humorous idea is that the victim would be unable to distinguish the bear's embrace from an attack.

Stanza 5 - Hyena and Crocodile

Answer: The poet humorously distinguishes the hyena by its laughing sound and the crocodile by its tears. The descriptions depend on popular associations with these animals.

Stanza 6 - Chameleon

Answer: The poet describes a chameleon as a small creature that is difficult to see because it blends with its surroundings. Its eyes are also described as unusual because they can look in different directions.

B. Thinking About the Poem - NCERT

1. Does 'dyin' really rhyme with 'lion'? Can you say it in such a way that it does?

Answer: In ordinary pronunciation, 'dyin'' and 'lion' do not perfectly rhyme. However, the poet uses a humorous, conversational pronunciation so that the words sound close enough to create the intended rhyme.

2. How does the poet suggest the tiger is dangerous?

Answer: The tiger is shown as a large, yellow animal with black stripes that can leap upon a person. The exaggerated situation makes the danger humorous rather than frightening.

3. What poetic device is used in 'novice' and 'dyin'?

Answer: The poet uses rhyme and humorous word choice. The informal spelling 'dyin'' contributes to the playful, conversational tone.

4. Can you find examples of alliteration in the poem?

Answer: Examples include phrases with repeated consonant sounds, such as 'very small' and other closely placed words. Alliteration adds rhythm and musicality to the humorous descriptions.

5. How does the poet make the poem humorous?

Answer: The poet gives absurdly practical advice about identifying dangerous wild animals after being attacked by them. The exaggerated situations, playful rhyme, repetition and ironic tone turn potentially frightening encounters into comedy.

C. Poetic Devices - How to Tell Wild Animals

Device	Effect / Explanation
Rhyme	Regular end-rhymes create a playful, song-like effect.

Device	Effect / Explanation
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds adds rhythm.
Repetition	Repeated words and sentence patterns reinforce the humorous descriptions.
Irony	The poem presents deadly encounters as if they were simple identification tests.
Hyperbole	The dangerous encounters are exaggerated for comic effect.
Imagery	Descriptions of colour, appearance and behaviour help readers visualise animals.
Enjambment	Some ideas continue across lines without a strong punctuation break.

D. Additional Questions - How to Tell Wild Animals

1. What is the central idea of the poem?

Answer: The poem humorously describes how one might identify different wild animals. Its main purpose is entertainment through exaggeration, rhyme, irony and playful descriptions.

2. Why is the poem called 'How to Tell Wild Animals'?

Answer: The title sounds like a practical guide, but the poet deliberately makes the advice absurd because the methods involve being attacked by the animal. This contrast creates humour.

3. How is humour created through danger?

Answer: The poet describes potentially fatal attacks in a cheerful and instructional tone. Treating dangerous situations as identification clues creates comic irony.

4. Why is the chameleon difficult to identify?

Answer: It blends with its surroundings and is therefore difficult to notice. The poet also highlights its unusual eyes, adding to the description.

5. What is the tone of the poem?

Answer: The tone is humorous, playful, witty and ironic rather than serious or frightening.

PART III - THE BALL POEM

John Berryman

A. Stanza-wise / Line-group Explanation

Opening situation

Answer: A boy loses his ball while playing. The loss is emotionally significant because the ball represents something familiar and personally valuable to him. The poet observes the boy's reaction rather than immediately replacing the ball.

The boy's grief

Answer: The boy becomes deeply sad as he watches the ball disappear. His reaction suggests that the loss is not only about the object but also about attachment and the first experience of losing something that cannot simply be recovered.

The poet's decision not to replace the ball

Answer: The poet could buy another ball, but he does not do so because the real lesson is not about the price of the object. The boy needs to experience loss and learn how to cope with it independently.

Learning the meaning of loss

Answer: The poem suggests that everyone must learn that possessions can be lost and that life involves separation. Such experiences gradually make a person mature and emotionally prepared to face larger losses.

B. Thinking About the Poem - NCERT

1. Why does the poet say, 'What is the boy now, who has lost his ball'?

Answer: The poet is interested in the emotional change caused by the loss. The boy is not merely without a ball; he is experiencing grief and learning an important lesson about loss for the first time.

2. Why does the poet not offer the boy money to buy another ball?

Answer: Replacing the ball would not replace the emotional experience. The boy needs to learn how to deal with loss and accept that some things cannot simply be recovered or bought again.

3. What does the phrase 'epistemology of loss' mean?

Answer: It refers to the understanding or knowledge gained through experiencing loss. The boy is beginning to understand that loss is a natural part of life and that people must learn to accept it.

4. What does the poet mean by 'the world of possessions'?

Answer: It refers to the material world in which people own, value and become attached to things. The poem suggests that growing up involves learning that possessions can be lost.

5. What does the boy learn from the loss of the ball?

Answer: He learns that loss is unavoidable and that emotional maturity involves accepting it. He begins to understand that not everything can be replaced and that one must learn to recover emotionally from loss.

C. Poetic Devices - The Ball Poem

Device	Explanation
Symbolism	The ball symbolises possessions, attachment, childhood and the experience of loss.
Repetition	Repeated references to the ball and loss emphasise the boy's emotional state.
Enjambment	Thoughts often continue across lines, reflecting the natural flow of the poet's observation.
Alliteration	Repeated consonant sounds add rhythm and emphasis.
Imagery	The poem creates a visual and emotional picture of the boy watching his ball disappear.

Device	Explanation
Metaphor	The 'world of possessions' works as a broader metaphor for material attachment and human experience.

D. Additional Questions - The Ball Poem

1. What does the ball symbolise?

Answer: The ball symbolises the things people become attached to and the inevitable experience of losing possessions. For the boy, it also represents a part of childhood.

2. Why is the loss of the ball important even though it is an ordinary object?

Answer: The object may be inexpensive, but the emotional attachment makes its loss important. It becomes the boy's first meaningful lesson in loss and acceptance.

3. Why does the poet remain a silent observer?

Answer: The poet understands that the boy must experience and process the loss himself. Intervening too quickly would prevent him from learning the emotional lesson.

4. What is the message of the poem?

Answer: The poem teaches that loss is an unavoidable part of life. People must learn to accept loss, manage grief and continue living rather than depending on material replacements.

5. How is the poem about growing up?

Answer: The boy's reaction shows a movement from childhood attachment towards emotional maturity. Learning to accept loss is one of the difficult but necessary experiences of growing up.

E. Important Words & Meanings - The Ball Poem

Grief

Answer: Deep sorrow caused by loss.

Possessions

Answer: Things that a person owns.

Desperate

Answer: Feeling or showing extreme distress or hopelessness.

Epistemology

Answer: The study or understanding of knowledge; here, knowledge gained through experience.

Rigid

Answer: Not flexible; firm or unchanging.

Merrily

Answer: Happily or cheerfully.

F. Combined Extract-Based Practice

‘The boy is learning to cope with loss.’

What kind of loss is described?

Answer: The boy loses his ball.

Why is the loss important?

Answer: It is his first significant experience of losing something he values.

What larger lesson does it represent?

Answer: It represents the unavoidable losses people face as they grow and mature.

‘If he lost his ball, he would be no less than a boy learning to cope with loss.’

What does the loss teach him?

Answer: It teaches acceptance and emotional resilience.

Why can’t money solve the problem completely?

Answer: A new ball can replace the object but cannot erase the emotional lesson.

What quality is developed?

Answer: Maturity and resilience are developed.

‘A wild animal may be identified through its behaviour.’

Which poem uses this idea humorously?

Answer: How to Tell Wild Animals.

What technique makes it funny?

Answer: Irony, exaggeration, rhyme and comic situations make it humorous.

Name one animal described.

Answer: Examples include the Asian lion, Bengal tiger, leopard, bear, hyena, crocodile and chameleon.

G. Important Quotations & Meanings

“I’ll rise and go / To seek my fortune.”

Answer: From the seagull’s experience, taking the first step is necessary before confidence develops.

“If he roars at you as you’re dyin’ / You’ll know it is the Asian Lion.”

Answer: A deliberately comic description that turns a dangerous encounter into an identification rule.

“No use to say—O there are other balls.”

Answer: Replacing the ball cannot replace the boy’s emotional experience or lesson.

“The epistemology of loss”

Answer: The understanding of loss gained through direct experience.

H. Value-Based Questions

1. What should a student do when fear prevents him or her from trying something new?

Answer: The student should identify the source of fear, prepare properly, seek guidance and take a small first step. Like the young seagull, experience can gradually replace fear with confidence.

2. What can we learn from the mysterious help in ‘The Black Aeroplane’?

Answer: The story encourages readers to recognise that difficult situations can contain unexpected possibilities, while also reminding us that some experiences may remain unexplained.

3. How should we respond to loss?

Answer: We should allow ourselves to feel sadness, accept that loss is part of life and gradually develop the strength to move forward. Material replacement alone cannot remove emotional loss.

4. How can humour make a serious topic easier to understand?

Answer: Humour can reduce fear and make an idea memorable. In 'How to Tell Wild Animals', dangerous encounters become entertaining, helping readers remember the characteristics of the animals.

I. CBSE Exam-Oriented Long Answers

1. Compare the two stories in 'Two Stories About Flying'.

Answer: 'His First Flight' is a story of personal growth. The young seagull is afraid to fly but finally succeeds when hunger and his mother's encouragement force him to act. 'The Black Aeroplane' is a story of mystery and suspense. The pilot enters a storm, loses his instruments and is guided to safety by a mysterious aircraft. Thus, the first story emphasises courage and self-confidence, while the second focuses on uncertainty and an unexplained experience.

2. How does 'His First Flight' teach the value of self-confidence?

Answer: The young seagull has the physical ability to fly but is held back by fear. He watches his family fly and remains on the ledge. His mother uses food to make him take the first step. Once he is in the air, he discovers that his wings support him. His fear disappears and he enjoys flying. The story shows that confidence often comes after we take action rather than before it.

3. How does humour contribute to 'How to Tell Wild Animals'?

Answer: The poem deals with dangerous wild animals but presents them in a playful way. The poet gives absurd instructions in which a person identifies an animal only after being attacked. Rhyme, repetition, exaggeration, irony and conversational language create humour. This light tone makes the poem entertaining and makes the characteristics of different animals easier to remember.

4. Explain the central idea of 'The Ball Poem'.

Answer: The poem presents a child's first meaningful experience of loss. The ball is an ordinary possession, but its loss causes genuine sadness because the child is emotionally attached to it. The poet does not simply replace it because the boy must learn to deal with loss himself. The poem suggests that growing up involves understanding that possessions can disappear and that life requires acceptance, resilience and emotional maturity.

J. Very Short Exam Questions

Who wrote 'His First Flight'?

Answer: Liam O'Flaherty.

Who wrote 'The Black Aeroplane'?

Answer: Frederick Forsyth.

Who wrote 'How to Tell Wild Animals'?

Answer: Carolyn Wells.

Who wrote 'The Ball Poem'?

Answer: John Berryman.

What does the young seagull fear?

Answer: He fears that his wings will not support him and that he will fall.

What motivates him to fly?

Answer: Hunger and his mother's strategy of tempting him with food.

What happens to the pilot's instruments?

Answer: His compass and radio stop working in the storm.

What is mysterious about the black aeroplane?

Answer: Its pilot guides the narrator to safety, but the control room reports no other aircraft.

Name the animal associated with laughing in the poem.

Answer: The hyena.

What does the chameleon symbolise in the poem?

Answer: It is described as a creature difficult to notice because it blends with its surroundings.

What does the lost ball symbolise?

Answer: It symbolises possessions, attachment and the experience of loss.

Why does the poet not replace the ball?

Answer: Because the boy needs to learn to cope with loss rather than simply receive a replacement.

K. Final Exam Preparation - Key Themes

His First Flight	Fear → encouragement/necessity → first attempt → discovery of ability → confidence.
The Black Aeroplane	Risk → storm → loss of instruments → mysterious guide → safety → unanswered mystery.
How to Tell Wild Animals	Wild animals → humorous identification → rhyme → irony → exaggeration → entertainment.
The Ball Poem	Attachment → loss → grief → acceptance → maturity → emotional resilience.

Note: This material is designed as a detailed study guide. For exact textbook wording of any individual NCERT question, students should refer to the current NCERT edition; the answers here are independently written and exam-oriented.